

What if a lot more services were brought down in one go? What if mobile phone networks of not just one service provider but multiple ones were down? What if the traffic control system of an entire city was down? What if all apps in Google Play store were infected with some bug? What if a new virus attacks and a lot of data is destroyed? You being a reader of Digit raises the probability that you know of stuxnet. What if something very similar hits all manufacturing systems and assembly lines go haywire? Already sounds like apocalypse? Well, it could be worse given the fact that we are all so dependent on computational systems already.

Fret not, the chances that all such things happen on a single day is pretty rare.

How bad can cyber-terrorism really be?

We started off with a narrow definition of targeting a small number of computers either specifically or randomly and went on broadening our imagination up till the effects of cyber terrorism activities could cause a mess huge enough to spark uncontrollable level of violence on streets. Most people are either in denial or disagree with the premise that cyber terrorism activities could surmount to a level that could possibly cause physical damage. One of the arguments that they can use to back themselves up is: "Who is going to do that?" We try to answer that question here.

Putting a range of computers on target is not a big deal. A single malicious hacker with the right tools, information and skill could do that. If the range were to be larger, the number of people behind the act ought to increase as well. This would be because a single person would not be able to take down large systems on his own due to time and resource constraints. We've already presented to you the scenario depicted in the movie *Live Free or Die Hard* but a movie is based on a number of assumptions. Though philosophical, the fight of good and evil is eternal without computing domain being an exception. Experts have said ever since that no system is perfectly safe and we have learnt to live with that. Incidents of breach take place everyday at various levels and the systems we work with, software, operating systems, networks and protocols are all vulnerable at some point. However, systems that we depend on, are heterogeneous - different operating systems, versions, update patches, network components, their software versions and updates and specific application vulnerabilities together pose a wide array of possibilities. From a hacker's viewpoint, as you go on increasing the number of target systems, you are going to need more hands and skilled brains.